



ChatGPT's Custom GPT Marketplace: State of Play in Late 2025

What Is the Custom GPT Marketplace?

The “Explore GPTs” section in ChatGPT is essentially an **app store for AI chatbots**. OpenAI launched the **GPT Store** in January 2024 to let users share and discover custom versions of ChatGPT ¹ ². These **Custom GPTs** are chatbots tailored to specific tasks or personalities, created by users by combining custom instructions, knowledge (e.g. uploaded files), and tool capabilities (like web browsing or image generation). In practice, the GPT Marketplace is a **catalog of user-made chatbots** accessible to ChatGPT Plus, Team, and Enterprise subscribers ³ ⁴. Each GPT has its own name, description, and icon, and behaves in a specialized way (for example, a “Travel Planner GPT” or a “Math Tutor GPT”). Users can browse categories or search by keywords to find GPTs that might help with a task, then **click to chat** with that custom GPT. In other words, OpenAI has turned ChatGPT into a platform, where the community supplies niche chatbots similar to how developers supply apps in a mobile app store ¹ ⁵.

Important: Despite the “marketplace” terminology, **currently everything is free to use** (for subscribers). When you select a community-made GPT, you don't pay for an individual bot – it's included in your ChatGPT subscription. The term “Store” refers to the discovery hub, not an actual e-commerce system (at least not yet). Think of it as a **library of chatbots** rather than a store with price tags.

Is It Really a “Marketplace” in 2025 (Any Monetization)?

As of November 2025, the GPT Store **does not facilitate direct purchases or payments** for individual GPTs – all usage is covered by the user's ChatGPT Plus/Enterprise plan. OpenAI **initially signaled plans for monetization** (revenue sharing) but has only rolled this out in a very limited way. When the store was announced, OpenAI said *“In Q1 we will launch a GPT builder revenue program... US builders will be paid based on user engagement with their GPTs.”* ⁶. In practice, OpenAI **invited only a small handful of top GPT creators** into a pilot program in 2024, offering them payouts for their bot's usage ⁷ ⁸. For example, one developer of a popular coding GPT (“Grimoire”) received an invite guaranteeing \$1,000/month minimum ⁷. However, **most GPT creators have not been able to monetize**: outside that invite-only pilot, there's *no mechanism for creators to earn money or charge users* in the marketplace (something confirmed by frustrated developers) ⁹ ¹⁰. OpenAI's help pages in late 2024 noted they *“hope to allow more builders to monetize their GPTs down the line”* ¹⁰, implying that a broader revenue-sharing or payment system is still forthcoming.

So, in 2025 the GPT “Marketplace” is a **marketplace in name more than reality** – it's a curated directory of free AI bots, not an open app economy. Creators cannot set prices, and users cannot purchase GPTs. The only “currency” is engagement (user uptake), which currently only yields monetary reward for a very select few creators. OpenAI *does* benefit indirectly (popular GPTs attract and retain subscribers), but individual builders generally do not get paid for high usage except via the pilot program. Many enterprising builders

have resorted to indirect monetization (e.g. inserting affiliate links or using their GPT's popularity to promote a paid product outside the platform) ¹¹ ¹² , but there's no native payment system for GPTs yet.

Will that change? OpenAI's leadership has consistently hinted that a true marketplace with revenue sharing is in the works. CEO Sam Altman said *"We're going to pay people who build the most useful and most-used GPTs a portion of our revenue."* ¹³ This suggests **eventual App-Store-like economics**, where top developers earn significant income. The initial timeline was early 2024 for rollout, but given delays and the pilot's small scale, it appears **full marketplace monetization has been slow to materialize**. By late 2025, there's still *no announcement of a general revenue program or ability to sell GPTs*. The expectation in the community is that **2026 might be the year** the GPT Store opens up financially (perhaps alongside new features or platforms like OpenAI's rumored GPT App Store on devices). For now, if you've published GPTs, you won't find any built-in way to "collect revenue" – it's simply not implemented broadly yet. OpenAI has a *strong incentive* to eventually enable transactions (to attract serious developers and higher-quality content, similar to how Apple's App Store growth was driven by third-party developer profits ¹⁴ ¹⁵), but as of November 2025 it remains **a free repository**. In summary: **not yet a money-making marketplace for the average creator**, though the foundation is being laid.

Size and Scope: How Many Custom GPTs Exist?

It's huge – on the order of millions of bots. OpenAI reported that within two months of launch, users had created over *3 million* custom GPTs ¹⁶ ² . That was in January 2024, and creation has continued since. By early 2024, new GPTs were being added at a rate of roughly **500–1,500 per day** ¹⁷ ¹⁸ . Extrapolating into 2025, the total number of GPTs ever created is likely in the several million (perhaps ~4–5 million by late 2025).

However, **not all GPTs are publicly listed in the Marketplace**. Creators can keep GPTs private or share them only via direct link. An analysis in January 2024 found that out of ~3 million total GPTs created, **only ~159,000 were "public" in the store** that month ¹⁹ ²⁰ . This means the vast majority were unlisted or internal (for personal or company use). To be publicly listed, a creator must mark the GPT "accessible to everyone" and verify their profile ²¹ . Many users likely created personal GPTs they didn't publish to the community.

As of November 2025, how many GPTs are in the Marketplace? OpenAI hasn't released an updated count, but it's certainly grown from that 159k. If we assume hundreds or thousands of new public GPTs appear each day, the store could easily have **a few hundred thousand public GPTs** by now. (For example, one third-party SEO analysis in late 2024 referenced "20,000+ best GPTs" and a search engine for them ²² ²³ , and that number was climbing.) The exact number is hard to pin down without official data, but it's safe to say **the marketplace contains hundreds of thousands of GPTs spanning all sorts of topics**. It's an expansive, **highly long-tail ecosystem** – everything from highly polished tools to quirky one-off bots.

Key facts and figures (as of 2024–2025):

- **Total custom GPTs created:** Over **3 million** by January 2024 ¹⁶ , and still growing (likely millions more in 2025). This reflects enormous interest – in just a few months, users built millions of chatbots. For comparison, Apple's App Store launched with 500 apps; the GPT Store had *millions* of submissions almost immediately.

- **Public GPTs listed in store:** Approximately **159,000** as of Jan 2024 ¹⁹ . This was about 5% of the total created. The public count today is higher, but even if it's say 300k or 500k now, it's still a subset of all GPTs made. Many GPTs remain private or unlisted.
- **Growth rate:** For most of 2024, the net addition of GPTs was in the **hundreds to low thousands per day** ¹⁷ . There were even days early on with ~1,500 new GPTs added in 24 hours ²⁴ . The pace may have fluctuated, but clearly hundreds of thousands of GPTs have been added since launch. (Notably, OpenAI did a one-time purge in Jan 2024 removing ~2,000 GPTs that violated guidelines ²⁵ , but growth resumed right after.)
- **Creators (developers) involved:** The marketplace is very decentralized. One early scrape of ~18,000 GPTs "in the wild" found they were built by ~10,000 unique creators ²⁶ – averaging under 2 GPTs per creator. This suggests **most people build 1 or 2 GPTs**, while a few build many. It's *not* like a few vendors making thousands of bots; rather, tens of thousands of individual users each contributed a small number. No single creator owns more than a tiny fraction (for one person to have 1% of all GPTs, they'd need to have made ~30,000 of them – which hasn't happened).
- **Plus user access:** The store initially was limited to paying users (Plus/Enterprise) ²⁷ . This restriction still holds – free users currently cannot browse or use custom GPTs. This gating naturally limits total usage and creation to the subset of users willing to pay for ChatGPT. (Plus is \$20/month in the US.) It also means the marketplace is *somewhat self-selecting* for enthusiasts, professionals, and companies.
- **Geographic reach:** It's a global phenomenon. Custom GPTs are being built and used worldwide. The U.S. accounts for the largest share of traffic (~13–15% in 2024) ²⁸ ²⁹ , but a majority of usage comes from other countries. Notably, many GPTs are in languages other than English. In the first 50k GPTs, about **37% of GPT descriptions were not in English**, indicating a significant multilingual presence (e.g. Chinese, Korean, Spanish GPTs, etc.) ³⁰ . Indeed, some of the most popular GPTs are non-English (more on this below).

In short, the **GPT Store's scale is already comparable to a large app repository**, measured in the hundreds of thousands of public entries (and millions of creations). This rapid growth underscores both the excitement and the *noise*: with so many GPTs, discoverability and quality control become major challenges (just like a crowded app store).

Categories and Genres of GPTs

To navigate this ocean of bots, GPTs are organized into **categories** in the UI. OpenAI's official store interface highlights **8 main categories** ³¹ :

- **Top Picks** – (OpenAI-curated popular GPTs or featured ones)
- **DALL·E** – image generation bots (GPTs that create or edit images)
- **Writing** – general writing assistance (from copywriting to storytelling)
- **Productivity** – tools for work, organization, and general task assistance
- **Research & Analysis** – academic research assistants, data analysis GPTs
- **Programming** – coding help, debugging assistants, code generators
- **Education** – tutors, language learning, study aids
- **Lifestyle** – personal assistants, hobbies, wellness, travel, etc.

(These roughly correspond to the examples OpenAI gave at launch: "categories like DALL·E, writing, research, programming, education, and lifestyle." ³²)

In practice, community sites and users sometimes use slightly different labels, but the above are the broad genres. For example, one unofficial directory (GPTStore.ai) groups GPTs into categories like “Virtual Assistants,” “Image Generation,” “Creative Writing,” “Coding Help,” “Personalized Learning,” and even SEO-focused GPTs – which largely map onto the official categories (SEO bots would fall under Productivity or Writing; coding help under Programming; personalized learning under Education; etc.). The key genres are **writing/content creation, coding/technical, research/data, image design, personal assistant, and education/training**, with a miscellaneous lifestyle category for everything else.

How many GPTs per category? OpenAI hasn’t published counts per category, but given the total volume, each broad category likely contains tens of thousands of GPTs. A third-party analysis from late 2023 of the *first 50k GPTs* found that **GPTs are often multi-purpose** (many span more than one function) and also *multi-lingual*, so categorization can blur ³⁰. Still, we can get a sense: a **huge proportion are in the “Writing” category** (all varieties of writing assistants, idea generators, blog or essay helpers). Education and coding are also heavily represented. An analysis of top GPT *descriptions* in early 2024 found that **4 of the top 10 keywords (40%) were education-related** (terms like “homework,” “essay writer,” “grammar checker,” “math solver” dominated), indicating education/homework bots were a major chunk of popular GPTs ³³. Meanwhile, only 1 of the top 10 was entertainment-focused ³⁴, suggesting relatively fewer successful GPTs in pure entertainment/games.

It’s reasonable to estimate that **content creation (writing, marketing, SEO)** and **student/scholarly assistance** GPTs each make up a large slice of the pie (perhaps each 20–30% of public GPTs), followed by **programming/coding helpers**, and then everything else (images, personal assistants, etc.). Many GPTs defy a single category – e.g. a “Career Coach” GPT might involve writing (resumes), productivity, and education at once – but broadly those are the buckets.

Notable category trends: The “**DALL·E**” (image) category, while smaller in number of GPTs, accounts for some of the *most used* bots (the #1 most-used GPT is an image generator). **Non-English/local language GPTs** became a de facto category – for instance, community builders created “ChatGPT in Korean,” “ChatGPT in Japanese,” “Spanish Tutor,” etc., which have their own audiences. These often appear under *Education* or *Lifestyle*, but one could see them as a linguistic category. In fact, **language-specific GPTs gained massive traction**, which we’ll see in the popularity stats below.

Overall, the Custom GPT marketplace spans **virtually every genre you can think of**: from business tools and coding assistants to writing coaches, language translators, customer service bots, recipe generators, game masters, trivia quiz bots, and more. If you can imagine a niche for an AI chatbot, chances are someone created a GPT for it. We are indeed *approaching “there’s a GPT for that.”* The breadth is similar to an app store – albeit with many experimental or overlapping entries (e.g. dozens of GPTs all claiming to summarize PDFs, or countless “write me an essay” bots).

Usage Patterns: Which GPTs Succeed (and What Users Click)

Despite the huge number of GPTs, **user attention is concentrated on a relatively small subset of them**. This is a classic long-tail scenario: a few hit “apps” get the lion’s share of usage, while most others languish. To quantify, an OpenAI forum analysis in early 2024 suggested that out of ~65,000 GPTs examined, **only ~300 had significant usage** – meaning *well under 1%* were getting almost all the traction ³⁵. Most custom GPTs might only have a handful of conversations (or none) beyond their creator testing them. This mirrors app stores where thousands of apps have zero downloads while the top charts get millions.

What are the most popular GPTs? Early data from March 2024 gives us a clear snapshot: the **top 10 GPTs** (by number of conversations/downloads) at that time were ³⁶ ³⁷ :

1. **Image Generator** – 6 million+ uses (AI image creation; ~176k reviews, 3.6★ rating) ³⁶
2. **Write For Me** – 5 million+ uses (AI writing assistant; 121k reviews, 4.2★) ³⁶
3. **Consensus** – 5 million+ uses (academic research search engine; 80k reviews, 4.3★) ³⁸ ³⁹
4. **Logo Creator** – 3 million+ uses (logo design bot; 172k reviews, 3.5★) ⁴⁰
5. **Canva (Design Assistant)** – 3 million+ uses (graphic design helper; 97k reviews, 3★) ⁴¹
6. **Scholar GPT** – 2 million+ uses (research paper assistant; 116k reviews, 4.2★) ⁴²
7. **Code Copilot** – 2 million+ uses (coding assistant; 71k reviews, 4.2★) ⁴³
8. **Humanizer Pro** – 2 million+ uses (converts AI text to more human-like text; 38k reviews, 3.8★) ⁴⁴
9. **Grimoire** – 2 million+ uses (advanced coding helper; 28k reviews, 4.4★) ⁴⁴
10. **VideoGPT** – 1 million+ uses (video generator; 53k reviews, 3.9★) ⁴⁵ ⁴⁶

These figures illustrate a few key trends: **practical content-generation tools dominated**. An image creator was #1 (likely because it turned ChatGPT into a free DALL-E alternative, which many users want), and multiple writing tools are in the top 10 (Write For Me, Humanizer). Several **education/research bots** rank high (Consensus, ScholarGPT) – showing students and researchers eagerly adopted GPTs that could search papers or help with homework. **Coding assistants** also rank (Code Copilot and Grimoire, which help with programming tasks). And even a **logo design** bot made it high on the list (indicating demand for AI in small business graphic design). By contrast, we see **almost no pure entertainment or chat-for-fun bots** in the top 10 – users gravitated to *utility*. OpenAI observed that many top GPTs are used for “creative, scholarly, data, or academic goals” rather than just jokes or casual chatting ⁴⁷ .

Another interesting trend: **localized GPTs for non-English languages soared in popularity**. For example, GPTStore.ai’s leaderboard (as of 2025) shows: a **Korean-language chatbot (“챗GPT”)** with **11M+ uses** ⁴⁸ , a **Japanese ChatGPT (“チャットGPT”)** with **9M+ uses** ⁴⁹ , and a **Spanish assistant (“Chat Español”)** with **3M+ uses** ⁵⁰ . These are essentially GPTs that output in a style adapted to those languages/cultures. Their success reveals a strong appetite for AI that feels tailored to one’s native language or context. Since the default ChatGPT was perceived as English-centric, these community-made GPTs filled a gap. In fact, the Korean and Japanese GPTs were among the top handful of GPTs globally by usage – a noteworthy feat. This suggests that **creating GPTs for major languages (Korean, Japanese, Spanish, etc.) was a “blue ocean” strategy early on**, capturing millions of users in those demographics.

Education-focused GPTs also thrive. Aside from ScholarGPT and Consensus, there are many homework helpers (unofficially nicknamed “HomeworkGPTs”). One such example is *Homeworkify* (a bot to solve textbook problems) which became popular. **About 40% of top GPT usage is in the education/homework realm** ³³ . Students use GPTs for writing essays, solving math, checking grammar – and custom GPTs that brand themselves for these tasks attracted clicks.

Content marketing and SEO GPTs form another significant niche. Many GPTs offer to write SEO-optimized blog posts, do keyword research, generate marketing copy, etc. While not all hit the very top, a few are quite popular (e.g., **“AI Humanizer”** with 4M+ uses is essentially an SEO tool to rewrite content to evade AI detectors ⁵¹ ⁵²). This indicates professionals in blogging/content fields are using the store.

Why do certain GPTs get so many clicks? A few reasons emerge: - They **address a common, broad need** (e.g. “make me an image,” “help me write something,” “find research for me”). Broad appeal yields high

usage. - They often had an **early-mover advantage or official backing**. Some top GPTs were featured by OpenAI at launch (Canva's, Khan Academy's, etc.) ⁵³ or built by known startups (Consensus app, AllTrails, etc.), getting initial promotion. Others just went viral among users. - **Simplicity and clear naming**: "Image Generator" is straightforward – anyone can understand what it does. This likely helped it become the go-to for image needs. Similarly, "Write For Me" clearly promises general writing help. GPTs with concise, descriptive names and obvious utility likely get more clicks than those with obscure or cutesy names. - **Quality and reviews**: The star ratings and reviews matter. Users see those before trying a GPT. Some top-used GPTs don't actually have stellar ratings (e.g. Image Generator at 3.6★, meaning output quality might be hit-or-miss), but *they have volume*. New users may click on something with **huge download counts** just out of curiosity or herd instinct ("if 5 million people tried this, I will too"). In contrast, thousands of GPTs with 0 reviews are essentially invisible.

Another pattern: **Many GPTs are redundant or very similar**, but one or two become the "winner" in that category. For instance, there might be 50 different "AI essay writer" GPTs – but one of them (say "*Write For Me*") captured the most users, perhaps by having a better prompt or just by luck/virality. Similarly, dozens of image-generation GPTs exist, but the one literally named "image generator" grabbed the top spot. This suggests **discoverability and slight initial boosts mean a lot** – once a GPT is trending, it snowballs.

Finally, **engagement vs. one-off use**: Some GPTs (like "Consensus" or "ScholarGPT") might foster repeated use because they perform a complex task (researching multiple queries, etc.). Others might be more one-and-done (generate an image and leave). It's notable that the top GPTs have *conversation counts* in the millions – these are cumulative, not unique users. For instance, "Image Generator" having 6+ million conversations ³⁶ means some users likely came back many times. GPTs that become true *utilities* see higher retention. A trivial or gimmicky GPT might get a user once and never again.

The long tail: On the flip side, *most* GPTs have minuscule usage. It was observed that out of tens of thousands, only a few hundred had more than a handful of conversations ³⁵. The median GPT might only be used by its creator and maybe a couple of curious clickers. Many are likely never discovered at all. This means the GPT Store, like any app ecosystem, has *lots of "dead" listings*. It's crowded – making it hard for a new GPT to break out without some edge.

Top Creators and Notable Contributors

You asked about individuals or groups who are especially prolific or influential in the GPT Marketplace. Given the scale, **no single person has anywhere near 1% of all GPTs** (1% of ~3 million would be 30,000 GPTs!). Even the most active builders have maybe a few hundred bots at most. For example, one power-user, *Josh Villocido*, a med student from the Philippines, built **over 250 GPTs** himself ⁵⁴. He created a "Books GPT" that was actually featured by OpenAI at launch and gained popularity ⁵⁴. Another enthusiast mentioned on Reddit built about 40 GPTs for various philosophical and practical purposes ⁵⁵. These are outliers – the *average* creator only made 1–2 GPTs ²⁶. So while a handful of people churned out dozens or hundreds of GPTs, they still collectively represent a small slice of the whole.

That said, **some names/organizations show up frequently as GPT creators** and have multiple hits:

- **Hix.AI** – This appears as the author of several GPTs (often ones with generic names like "GPT Chat Free Online", "OpenChat AI GPT", etc., which each have hundreds of thousands of uses ⁵⁶ ⁵⁷).

Hix.ai is an AI startup, and they seem to have leveraged the GPT Store to publish various chatbots for brand visibility. They have at least half a dozen GPTs (English and non-English) that gained significant usage. Essentially, Hix.AI treated the GPT Store as a marketing channel for their AI services.

- **GPTOnline.ai** – Another entity that made multiple language-specific GPTs. For instance, GPTOnline.ai is behind the popular Korean and Spanish GPTs that have millions of uses ⁵⁸ ⁵⁹ . They likely created a series of localized GPTs (“ChatGPT in X language”) and effectively cornered that niche early.
- **AwesomeGPTs (and affiliates)** – “AwesomeGPTs.ai” or `.vip` is a moniker that appears on a variety of GPTs (they publish prompts on GitHub too). They have created GPTs like “Scholar AI”, “Academic Assistant Pro”, “Professional Coder”, etc., some of which have hundreds of thousands of uses ⁶⁰ ⁶¹ . This seems to be a community or team dedicated to crafting prompt-engineered GPTs at scale.
- **Pulsr** – Pulsr.co.uk is behind a series of “world’s most powerful X” GPTs (\$PULSR prompts) such as a math GPT, a writing GPT, an image generator pro, etc. ⁶² ⁶³ . They have multiple GPTs with usage in the hundreds of thousands or millions. It looks like a strategy to cover multiple domains under one brand.
- **Individual entrepreneurs** – People like *Nick Dobos* (creator of “Grimoire”, a coding GPT, with 2M+ uses) and *Adrian Lin* (creator of “Copywriter GPT” with ~500k uses) have made a mark ⁷ ⁶⁴ . Nick’s success even landed him in the revenue pilot. Another name is *NAIF ALOTAIBI*, who appears as author of top GPTs like the #1 Image Generator and a GPT-Excel tool ⁶⁵ ⁶⁶ . He likely created several high-performing GPTs and thus is a notable builder.

No single creator dominates usage, but **OpenAI’s launch partners also deserve mention**: companies like **Khan Academy (Khanmigo)**, **Canva**, **AllTrails**, **Wolfram**, and **Kayak** all published official GPTs ⁵³ ⁶⁷ . These tended to be well-built and some were featured (Khan Academy’s “Code Tutor” GPT was featured ⁶⁸ , as was Canva’s design GPT). While these companies might not have quantity, their GPTs often received a quality spotlight and lots of user trials.

In terms of **who “owns” many GPTs**, it’s a very long tail of thousands of individual creators. The largest *single* GPT contributor making headlines was the student with 250+ GPTs (Villocido) ⁵⁴ . Even he is a fraction of a percent of total GPTs. So it’s not like the App Store where big studios pump out hundreds of apps – here even the top builders are hobbyists or small teams creating tens of bots.

Leadership by usage vs count: If we look at *usage*, some startups have effectively “won” certain categories (e.g. Consensus AI’s GPT, or the AI image generator by a user, got millions of uses). But there’s not yet a clear **“GPT millionaire”** class broadly, because monetization is limited. Some folks have parlayed GPT success into VC funding (the team behind *Consensus*, for example, raised funds after showcasing their GPT’s popularity ¹²). So the marketplace’s impact is more about **exposure and user base** right now than direct revenue per creator.

On average, a Plus user might try a handful of GPTs and stick to a few favorites. Likewise, the average creator only makes 1 GPT. So the ecosystem’s creation and consumption are still relatively shallow per capita, with a few doing a lot. Over time, if monetization kicks in, one might see more professional “GPT developers” emerging, just as the App Store eventually had companies dedicated to app development. 2025 is still early – mostly enthusiasts and early adopters.

How to Stand Out: Marketing Your GPT in a Crowded Store

Given the scarcity of public data, we have to glean indirectly *how one might optimize a custom GPT for more visibility and usage*. Drawing parallels from the App Store and from patterns we see:

1. Solve a Real Problem or Fulfill a Desire: The GPTs that take off generally **offer clear utility**. Ask yourself: *What will someone use my GPT for, and is that something many people want?* If it's too niche or vague, it may not get traction. The early “gold rush” winners were homework helpers, coding aids, image creators, writing assistants – all high-demand areas. If you target a high-impact category (e.g. study help, content creation, coding, language learning), you increase your odds ³³ ⁴⁷. That said, there's competition there, so a *twist* or improved approach helps (maybe your homework GPT also teaches concepts, etc., to differentiate).

2. Optimize Your GPT's Listing (Title & Description = SEO): The GPT Store has a search function, and many users also find GPTs via Google search (over 6 million monthly Google visits in early 2024 went to GPT links!) ⁶⁹ ⁷⁰. This means your GPT's **name and description should contain the keywords** people might search. For example, if you create a travel assistant GPT, having words like “travel,” “trip planner,” “itinerary” in the name/description will help it appear in relevant searches. Avoid overly creative but inscrutable names – *clarity trumps cleverness*. A user scrolling the store should instantly know what your GPT does. For instance, “Resume Reviewer GPT” is likely to attract more clicks than something abstract like “Career Wizard” without context. Think in terms of **App Store Optimization (ASO)**: use concise titles, and pack the description with use-case keywords (without spamming). Many successful GPTs literally have names that match what the user wants (e.g. “SQL Expert”, “SEO Blog Writer” etc. appear in the SEO category ⁷¹ ⁷²).

3. Use a Good Icon: This might sound minor, but visually, when browsing the store, each GPT has an icon. GPT creators can upload a custom image or pick an emoji. A professional-looking, relevant icon can make your GPT appear more credible and eye-catching in lists. Since dozens of GPTs might have similar names, an icon can create a *branding* advantage. For example, a distinct logo for your “French Tutor GPT” might catch attention versus a default icon next to competing language GPTs.

4. Ensure High-Quality Outputs (Especially Early on): The first users of your GPT will essentially “beta test” it and may leave a star rating or review. These ratings matter – new users often filter or gravitate to GPTs with ≥ 4 stars. If your GPT launches with sloppy prompt design and gives poor answers, it could quickly accumulate low ratings (or simply not retain users). Test it thoroughly, maybe with friends or colleagues, to fine-tune its responses. A well-crafted system prompt and appropriate use of file uploads or tools will make your GPT more genuinely useful, which translates to better user feedback. In the long run, **quality = better retention and word-of-mouth**. There are many “one-sentence prompt” GPTs out there that don't add much value (a user in the OpenAI forum noted “*most of the ones on the store are crap, just one sentence prompts*” ⁷³). Don't be one of those – put some effort so that yours stands out as *substantive*. Users can tell when a GPT actually has depth versus when it's something they could've done by just typing into ChatGPT themselves.

5. Leverage Unique Data or Capabilities: One way to differentiate is to give your GPT capabilities that others lack. For example, you can attach **custom knowledge** (by uploading PDFs, docs, etc.) – if you create a finance advisor GPT loaded with up-to-date market data (via files) or a medical Q&A GPT loaded with a dataset of medical guidelines, it will perform better in those domains than a generic GPT. Similarly, enable the right **tools** for your GPT: if web browsing is useful for its task, turn it on; if image generation or code

execution is relevant, allow those. A GPT that can do multi-step actions or access external info can outshine one that doesn't. *Example:* A "Real Estate Analysis GPT" that can browse Zillow listings in real time (using web access) and then calculate investment metrics (using the code interpreter) would be far more powerful (and attractive to users) than a static GPT that only knows old data. Custom GPTs all use GPT-4 under the hood, so the playing field is level there – the differentiator is what instructions and tools you layer on. Use that to your advantage.

6. Pick the Right Category: When you publish a GPT, you choose which category it appears in. **Make sure you choose appropriately and maybe strategically.** If your GPT could fit under multiple categories, consider where competition is lower. For instance, say you made a "Nutrition Coach" GPT – that might fall under *Lifestyle* or *Education*. If *Lifestyle* has fewer popular GPTs compared to *Education*, placing it in Lifestyle might get it featured or noticed more easily. The SEO.ai stats indicated the main official categories and that "Top Picks" is curated ⁷⁴. You probably can't get into Top Picks manually (that's OpenAI-curated), but you can aim for categories where your GPT fills a gap. Some categories (like Programming or Writing) are saturated with high-quality entries; others like Lifestyle or even Research might have room for more specialization.

7. Promote Outside the Platform: Don't rely solely on the in-app discovery. Especially if you have a niche GPT that might not trend organically, **share it on social media, relevant forums, or with communities who would benefit.** For example, if you built a "Dungeon Master GPT" for tabletop RPG players, share the link on Reddit's r/DnD or gaming forums. If it's genuinely useful, this can kickstart usage. External traffic can boost your GPT's ranking internally (since the store likely notices it getting popular). We saw that some GPT links were circulated on Twitter, Reddit, etc., driving their usage up. The Vox article author mentioned spending "an ungodly amount of time" playing with chatbots in 2023 and being overwhelmed by choice ⁷⁴ – many potential users don't even know what GPTs exist. Targeted promotion can connect your GPT with its audience. *Tip:* You can also create a short demo video or write a blog explaining how to use your GPT – education helps adoption, especially if the GPT has a learning curve.

8. Encourage Feedback and Iteration: Treat your GPT like a product. Encourage users to leave feedback (maybe in the description or via a contact if you provided one). You can update your GPT's prompt over time to improve it. If you notice drop-off in usage, try to understand why – was it not answering well for certain queries? Did it hit tool limits? Regularly updating it (and noting updates in the description) can also signal to users that it's maintained. Some of the top GPTs have version numbers or update notes in their description (e.g., "v1.3 updated 30/10/24" seen in some GPT listings ⁷⁵ ⁷⁶). This builds trust that the bot is cared for.

9. Watch the Trends: Keep an eye on the GPT Store's trending or leaderboard section. See what *new* GPTs are rising. This can give insight into user interests. For instance, if you suddenly see many popular GPTs about "AI detector bypass" or "cover letter writer," that's a clue that demand exists there. You could either join that trend (with a unique spin or better quality) or find a counter-trend (an underserved niche). Early 2024 stats showed trending keywords in descriptions like "midjourney" (image) and "uncrop" (image editing), as well as "voice generator" ⁷⁷ – indicating people were even using GPTs to interface with other AI tools (like generate prompts for Midjourney, etc.). Being aware of what users are actively searching for can inform your GPT-building strategy.

10. Ethically "Game" the System: There's no hack to instantly make your GPT popular (and attempting artificial boosts could violate OpenAI's policies). But you can **capitalize on how the store algorithm likely works.** It probably looks at engagement (conversations started) and momentum (how quickly a GPT gains

users). Therefore, concentrating your promotion and user onboarding in a short window can push your GPT into the “trending” list, which then exposes it to all Plus users. For example, if you plan a launch, have a bunch of friends/colleagues try it out and share around the same day. A spike of usage might get it featured in “trending GPTs” on the homepage. Once it’s there, many more users will click out of curiosity, creating a virtuous cycle. This is akin to mobilizing downloads and reviews in the first 48 hours of an app launch to climb the charts. **Caution:** Don’t use bots or fake accounts to inflate usage – that could get your GPT taken down. But rallying genuine users early on is a **legitimate strategy to game the attention economy** in your favor.

11. Comply with Policies and Guidelines: OpenAI has strict usage policies for public GPTs ⁷⁸. Any GPT with disallowed content will be removed (and they do review GPTs before listing). So don’t attempt to make a GPT that produces inappropriate or harmful outputs as a “shock tactic” for popularity – it won’t fly. Also, avoid using trademarked names or pretending to be an official brand (some GPTs that infringed IP likely got removed). Staying policy-compliant ensures your GPT can actually stay up and potentially be featured. OpenAI even has *GPT Brand Guidelines* to prevent confusion (e.g., you shouldn’t use their logo or name improperly) ⁷⁹. Treat this like launching an app – follow the rules so your work isn’t yanked after all your effort.

In essence, **to succeed in the GPT Marketplace, think like an app entrepreneur:** identify a need, build a quality solution, optimize your “store listing” (name, icon, description) for discovery, and promote the heck out of it through the right channels. We are early in this space – it’s 2008 App Store all over again ⁸⁰ – so creators who combine good ideas with savvy marketing can become the frontrunners before the field gets more professionalized.

The Road Ahead: A GPT Store Economy by 2026?

You astutely compared the GPT Store’s trajectory to the Apple App Store or Google Play in their early days. We’re seeing similar patterns: explosive growth in content, lots of experimentation, a few breakout successes, and the platform owner (OpenAI) gradually working out how to regulate and monetize the ecosystem. The big question: *Will the GPT Marketplace become an actual, transaction-enabled economy?*

All signals suggest **Yes – eventually**. OpenAI themselves frame the GPT Store as a **market platform** connecting users and builders, and explicitly mention plans for revenue sharing and monetization features ⁶ ¹³. They likely view it as a strategic moat: if they have the most developers *and* users engaged in a thriving marketplace, it strengthens ChatGPT’s network effects ⁸¹ ⁸². It’s similar to how Apple’s App Store locked in iPhone users with a huge app selection. An HBR analysis in May 2025 noted that the GPT Store was key to OpenAI’s platform strategy and that *network effects* (users attract builders, builders create content to attract more users) were beginning to kick in ⁸¹ ⁸³. But they also pointed out it’s early and those effects are weaker than classic app stores – likely because monetization isn’t fully there yet to supercharge developer participation ⁸¹ ¹⁴.

By 2026, we can expect **more formalization**: OpenAI will probably open the revenue program to more creators (perhaps based on certain usage thresholds or application process). They might introduce a **payment system or credit system** where Plus users can spend tokens on premium GPTs or extra services within GPTs. It wouldn’t be surprising if GPT creators eventually can sell *subscriptions* or *packs* (imagine paying a few dollars for a GPT that has continually updated proprietary data or special capabilities). OpenAI

might also implement an **advertising or sponsorship model**, but given the focus on user experience, a rev-share (like YouTube or App Store 70/30 split) is more likely ⁸⁴ ⁸² .

We should also watch **Google's moves** – you mentioned the “forthcoming Gem Store for Google Gemini Gems.” Google's Gemini (a rival AI model) is expected to have some sort of marketplace (“Gems” possibly being sharable AI agents). If Google allows direct charging or integrates with Play Store, OpenAI will feel pressure to not lag behind. Competition could accelerate the development of a true GPT economy.

If/when the marketplace becomes actual “There's a GPT for that” app store: - *Expect a flood of higher-quality entrants.* Once money flows, professionals and companies will invest in building GPTs (just as mobile dev shops sprang up). The hobbyist era will evolve to a more polished app-like era. We might see major brands release official GPTs (imagine an **official Wikipedia GPT**, or a **WebMD GPT** for health, etc., perhaps sold or free but upselling something). - *Discovery will become even more crucial.* OpenAI will likely refine the store interface – possibly adding **sub-categories**, **“Editor's Picks,” trending for the week, new releases, etc.** SEO and marketing tactics will get more sophisticated. The current state – where some great GPTs are hidden unless you search – will improve with better curation and search ranking algorithms. Creators might need to do ongoing ASO as the store changes. - *User expectations will rise.* Right now, many users will tolerate that a free community GPT might be buggy or not perfect. But if they start paying or if the overall quality bar rises, GPTs will need to deliver reliable value. This means prompt engineering will get more advanced, possibly GPTs chaining multiple steps or integrating external APIs to differentiate. Essentially, **GPTs could become more like full “apps”** (with multi-turn dialogues as the UI/UX). - *Analytics for creators:* OpenAI provides only rudimentary stats to most creators (number of conversations, rough engagement). In the Wired piece, developers lamented the lack of detailed analytics ⁸⁵ ⁶⁴ . For a true marketplace, creators will demand better analytics (installs, DAU, retention, etc.), and OpenAI would likely provide a dashboard akin to App Store Connect or Google Analytics for GPTs. This would help creators optimize and also decide how to monetize (e.g., which GPTs are worth investing more in). - *Monetization models:* Perhaps not everything will be user-paid. OpenAI might fund top creators via an expanded **creator fund** (similar to how YouTube has an ads revenue share, or how some app stores have developer incentive programs). They already did the pilot of \$1k/month guarantees ⁸⁶ . We could see a scenario where OpenAI shares a portion of Plus subscription revenue proportional to usage of a creator's GPT (kind of how Spotify pays musicians per stream). In fact, the initial plan to pay based on “user engagement” hints at this model ⁶ . Over time, if GPTs integrate external APIs or services, there could be **affiliate revenue** or transactions within conversations (imagine ordering a product via a shopping GPT – the GPT creator or data provider might get a cut). The marketplace could evolve beyond just Q&A bots to commerce facilitation.

In summary, **the GPT Marketplace in late 2025 is at an inflection point:** it's rich with content and user interest, but the monetization and structure are nascent. It's *highly reminiscent of the early App Store (circa 2008–2009)*: tons of novelty apps, a few hits, developers exploring possibilities, and debate on what business models will emerge. Your intuition that we'll soon say “I've got a GPT for that” as commonly as “there's an app for that” is very plausible. The timeframe of that maturation could indeed be 2026, as more players (OpenAI, Google, maybe Microsoft with Bing AI) build out their stores.

For a creator right now: this is the time to learn the ropes, establish a presence, maybe even build a small portfolio of GPTs with growing user bases. If you can capture a niche and build a following (even if unpaid), you position yourself to benefit when the marketplace does introduce revenue-sharing. Early App Store developers who built popular apps by 2009 were in a *prime position* to scale those into big businesses in the following years. We might see analogous success stories with GPT builders. The Wired article's title, “GPT

Store has left some developers in the lurch,” captures that some expected to make money already and are disappointed ⁸⁷ . But it's likely a matter of time. OpenAI is being cautious, possibly to avoid spam and low-quality gold rush before they can moderate it. Once they open the gates to monetization, those who **combined great GPT ideas with savvy promotion and consistent quality** will reap the rewards.

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